

Chicago Tribune



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BREAKING NEWS AT CHICAGOTRIBUNE.COM

MICHAEL MADIGAN TRIAL

Landmark case in the jury's hands

Panel must sort through recordings, documents, 27 hours of closing arguments to reach verdict

By Jason Meisner, Megan Crepeau and Ray Long
Chicago Tribune

Nearly four months after they were first called to Chicago's federal courthouse, jurors have begun

deliberating in the most consequential Illinois public corruption case in years: the racketeering case of former House Speaker Michael Madigan and his longtime confidant, Michael McClain.

The panel was sent back to delib-

erate about 3:15 p.m. Wednesday after attorneys presented roughly 27 hours of closing arguments this week and last. Jurors will have to consider 23 counts against Madigan alleging an array of schemes to enrich his political allies and line his pockets. McClain is charged in six of those counts.

To assist their deliberations, jurors have about 100 pages of

legal instructions, dozens of undercover recordings, and hundreds of emails, texts and other documents entered into evidence.

The trial dragged on significantly longer than expected. It began with jury selection in early October and was slated to wrap up before Christmas. But unexpected witness change-ups, lengthy legal arguments and Madigan's choice to

testify on his own behalf — among other factors — kept proceedings going for nearly four months.

Within half an hour of being sent back to the jury room, the jurors sent U.S. District Judge John Robert Blakey their first note, setting their own deliberation schedule, requesting an updated

Turn to Madigan, Page 2

Under Trump administration's expanded powers, an Elgin father who has been in the country for more than two decades gets swept up and turned over to ICE processing center during an operation targeting someone else

A family says, 'why him?'

Chicago man, fresh out of prison, pleads for grace in taped arrest

By Caroline Kubzansky
Chicago Tribune

As U.S. Immigration and Customs Enforcement agents led Sai Pavuluri out of his Northwest Side home in handcuffs, he turned to look at the camera crew recording his arrest.

He wore shorts and a T-shirt. His face offered no discernible expression.

Several feet away, Dr. Phil McGraw — a TV talk show host who, along with his camera crew, was embedded with Homeland Security agents as they launched an immigration blitz in the Chicago area on Sunday — opined on the arrest in keeping with his role of de facto spokesman for the operation.

In another video shared on social media, Pavuluri is shown sitting inside a black sedan as a federal agent opens the door and allows a reporter from the pro-Donald Trump website Frontline America to stick a microphone in the 31-year-old man's face and question him. Pavuluri, who was born in India, explained he had been in prison since 2018, serving an eight-year sentence for a drunken driving incident that killed 20-year-old Mariyah Howard, of Beecher.

He had been released from prison only 16 days earlier, according to Illinois Department of Correction records. Looking into the camera, he asked for a "fair chance" and pleaded for grace from no one in particular.

"I did something wrong," said Pavuluri, who was in the country on a student visa at the time of the crash. "I'm sorry about what I did."

Immigration and Customs Enforcement has not released detailed information about its arrests this week, leaving Pavuluri's detention as one of the few cases tacitly confirmed by the agency. With ICE refusing to say how

Turn to Arrest, Page 4



Sanjuana Ramos, right, the wife of Raul Lopez, and their daughter, Jacky Lopez, 19, console each other on Tuesday following Raul's arrest in Elgin. STACEY WESCOTT/CHICAGO TRIBUNE

By Laura Rodríguez Presa, Nell Salzman and Gloria Casas
Chicago Tribune

An undocumented Elgin father who has been in the country for more than two decades was swept up in a fugitive investigation targeting his stepson, a scene captured in a harrowing video that went viral on social media.

Raul Lopez, 44, was brought to the U.S. Immigration and Customs Enforcement processing center in suburban Broadview after his wife and daughters were physically pulled out of their Elgin home by federal agents with the U.S. Marshals Service on Tuesday morning. The agents were there for Jose Ramos, 26, Lopez's stepson who was wanted on an attempted murder charge.

But Ramos was not home when officials entered the house. Agents instead arrested Lopez, who had been hiding in an attic during the raid. Sanjuana Ramos, his wife, recalled holding their 3-year-old in her arms while the agents handcuffed her husband. Their daughters were crying. She said the agents told her, "We have to take someone."

"But why him?" she said she asked after begging the agents to check his records. "He's got nothing, no criminal record at all aside from being undocumented."

A week into Donald Trump's second presidency and his nationwide efforts to crack down on illegal immigration, federal officers are operating with a new sense of mission: Under Trump, officers can now arrest people without legal status if they run across them while looking for migrants targeted for removal. Under President Joe Biden, such "collateral arrests" were banned.

During a White House briefing Tuesday, press secretary Karoline Leavitt was asked how many of

Turn to Father, Page 4

■ The Trump administration says it plans to send immigrants in the U.S. without legal permission to Guantanamo Bay. **Nation & World**

OIG: Mayor's office blocked access to gift room

By Alice Yin and Jake Sheridan
Chicago Tribune

Mayor Brandon Johnson's office improperly blocked public access to a City Hall room where mayoral staff said they've stored Gucci bags, designer cufflinks and other gifts, according to an investigation by the city's Office of the Inspector General.

A report released Wednesday

by Inspector General Deborah Witzburg found Johnson's office violated the city's ethics policy that requires mayors to record gifts above \$50 and "accepted on behalf of the City" in a publicly available log maintained on the fifth floor of City Hall. Covert OIG investigators visited the mayor's office last June but were denied access to the log.

Johnson on Wednesday called

the report a "mischaracterization."

The report says Johnson's staff refused to hand over the list of gifts and directed the undercover investigators to make a Freedom of Information Act request instead. The mayor's office then allegedly blew past the deadline to respond and only produced an

Turn to Gifts, Page 5

Trump rescinds chaotic federal funding freeze

By Chris Megerian, Zeke Miller and Lisa Mascaro
Associated Press

WASHINGTON — President Donald Trump's budget office on Wednesday rescinded a memo freezing spending on federal loans and grants, less than two days after it sparked widespread confusion and legal challenges across the country.

The memo, which was issued Monday by the Office of Management and Budget, had frightened states, schools and organizations that rely on trillions of dollars from Washington.

Administration officials said the pause was necessary to review whether spending aligned with Trump's executive orders on issues like climate change and diversity, equity and inclusion

programs. But Wednesday, they sent out a two-sentence notice rescinding the original memo. The reversal was the latest sign that even with unified control of Washington, Trump's plans to dramatically and rapidly reshape the government has limits.

The decision to pull the directive was a significant reversal

Turn to Freeze, Page 5



AUDREY RICHARDSON/CHICAGO TRIBUNE

Chicagoans shelling out for some eggs

Egg prices are soaring above \$10 per dozen in some Chicagoland stores amid a national bird flu outbreak, and it might only get worse. **Business**

TODAY'S WEATHER High 53 Low 38

Complete Chicagoland forecast on Page 14

\$4.00 city and suburbs and elsewhere
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